

Under Control

I wish I could say I liked alcohol
but it burns, when I drink
I guess I know why it's called a shot
'cause vodka pricks as a needle stings
but what scares me more than the taste
I fear is slipping from the reins
for in normal times I overthink and overthink and overthink
...the words I say and the things I do...
how can I trust a version of me
that's not... *really* me?

drank and drunk and dizzy and woozy
tomato-red flushed face —
hot or shy or embarrassed or intoxicated
i can't really tell
it's all the same to me
my body is one and my feelings are two
but it's all the same one in one twisted pot
melting and melding my fears and inhibitions
evaporating into thick steam my mental strife
it's disgusting
how much the air reeks of anxiety
of a desire to be perfect
that's not... really me

Moses Yang

Through the mud

I still remember
the time when I played
my perfect, golden, horn.
I could show my emotions,
and tell all my stories,
with a tube of metal
and a puff of wind.

Time for 2nd period;
it's band class.
Smells of metallic spit;
it's familiar.
We're playing some march;
it's staccato.

But as the melody starts,
I start to lose track, and
my upbeats are downbeats
downbeats are upbeats
my upbeats are—
Stop! Stop! You're Slow!
My band teacher shouts:
you play like you're dragging
a fridge through the mud!

And without a thought,
I start to imagine:
my feet stuck in slush,
slick yet strangled and
choked to submission
as I
Push! Push! Push into the ground!

But the fridge right behind me,
attached by a rope—He
tightens his grip, with
knuckles white, and a
cheesy grin, digging his

Moses Yang

claws deep into my back.

It hurts like hell, but
if I don't run now, I know
I never will. So I
dig my digits deep
slowly move forward, but
at this pace, it won't be
enough.

I won't get to the end,
the white checkered flag,
where the chords will strike,
and the gong will hit. I'm
sinking and drowning
breathless
as the mud drinks my shoes.

But like a crescendo, I
start soft and slow.
If I crawl and I crawl,
and I crawl and I crawl,
at this rate, it will be

Enough!

My band teacher screams.
If you're just gonna sleep,
you might as well sleep.
But don't do it here,
not in my room,
where you slow down my rhythm:

Dragging

a fridge

through

the mud.

Sweeping

Every April, he visits his mother.
He's home, but still far from home.

Whispers "You missed me, ma?" and
catches a glistening glare, for his mother had
sat by her phone, brown eyes glazed over,
waiting for a call from her only son.

The light catches her eyes cruelly and
his heart skips a beat, failing to strike
when their eyes meet. On his knees,
holding his tears tight to his chest,
he begs her for forgiveness.

He hopes and prays it's enough
it's not
and offers to sweep her
house so she can rest.

He sees her sweeping too,
swiping the dusty sweat off her
furrowed brows in the summer
heat; her wrinkles trace rugged paths
through her face when she smiles,
cheeks tight as if to hint at the
weariness she carries in her bones.

He hears her humming to the tune
of her favorite melodies as she buzzes
around like a worker bee with places to be
and flowers to see in the spring.
He can hear her feet shuffling,
locked in rhythm with the
groaning of the stairs and the
gossip of the broom as she sweeps.

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He sweeps now.

sweep

sweep

sweep.

He makes her bed, and
kisses her on the forehead,
wiping her overgrown hair
away from her rough, cutting skin.
Her bed is clean now, but she
refuses to lift the covers and
drape his body with a hug.

The stone is cool to touch
blistering
his fingers as he rubs his
thumb gingerly across the stiff patterns
that can only capture but a summary
of her vivacious and joyous life.

He weeps now.

weep

weep

weep.

Moses Yang

A Kiss Between

a snowflake

Windy,
winding,
winded.

I whip my wings
and wear a wink
'cause I know I can fly.

Fly high,
feel the sky—
hold me tight;
I'm scared.

Here I hold some
wisps of wear
I sip a sip
of wine and whine.

The sky is mine—
the star of the show!

But I miss
way back when
comfort of clouds
friends in flakes
secure security

I'm falling now.

A tree.

A kiss.

and a tree

A kiss.

A snowflake.

I'm glittering now.

All I want
there and then
freedom of flight
spacious space
flexed flexibility

The earth is mine—
the king of the kingdom!

Here I hold and
grasp the ground
my roots rooted;
I'm moved to move.

Fly high,
feel the sky—
wander the world;
for me.

I leave my leaves
and break my branches
'cause I know I can't fly.

Gritty,
grinding,
grounded.

Moses Yang

Writer's Block

Looming ahead, it
cackles with delight.
It's ruinous, built to
ruin us, layer upon layer
of blood-red brick.

The wall is
unfaltering
unwavering
unrelenting.

My words
hold space
so I can
be empty.

My words
are empty
so I can't
hold space.

Snaking towards and along the wall,
they slither slick in silence.
Crissing and crossing,
they overlap with connivance.
Whispering cryptic riddles of illusion,

The paths are

illegible

illogical

illadvisable.

Time to turn back
time's turn now:

Can't I just

turn
around

and put this all behind me?

Moses Yang

Trudging Downstream

ten feet underwater
my feet are dredges
shoveling through the
cemented sediment

up, forward, away
 up, forward, away
up, forward, away
 up, forward, away

edging onwards but
my shoes in the sand
feeling
the sand in my shoes
teaming up with gravity
hoping to
swallow me whole

just take me in
embrace me
and pucker up
to kiss me
at least then
I won't be

alone

at 4 in the afternoon
my stomach is angry
punching out my chest
begging to
grapple through my mouth
looking to
shred with my canines

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because I've
neglected him
abused him
punished him

since 9 in the morning
I've been quivering in my
off-white white sneakers
crusted with dust from
three rains ago

stifled by the choice
of four different hoodies
and two different chinos

as if
I would be any cooler
would be any hotter
from the mixing and matching
of six different colors

my ego is scattered and shattered like
the diffraction of light
through the running water

afraid of the long lines
waiting for food
spotting someone I know
but don't really *know*
an awkward wave
a whispered hello

They must not know my name,
so I wait until 4 before I eat my meal.

I swim alone
a fish out of water
as a fish inside water
fighting downstream
when the rest fly up

Moses Yang

Apart from a part / A part of apart

my heart

fails to keep

learns to keep

your touch

your sound

your scent

close

far

between

within

my brain

my body

my home

quivers

empty

for you.

Moses Yang

The [REDACTED] Brown shooting [REDACTED] concerns.

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

We [REDACTED] discuss [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] concerns surrounding
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] the Brown University shooting [REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] cancel [REDACTED] the
[REDACTED]

“America [REDACTED] in [REDACTED] tragedies like [REDACTED] at Brown and MIT [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] We [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] are empowered [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] keep Americans safer. [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] a generation of people [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] they don't feel safe [REDACTED] communities [REDACTED] don't feel
safe [REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] is [REDACTED] safety [REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] valued [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

the United States [REDACTED]

[REDACTED]
[REDACTED] was responsible for both the Brown shooting and the killing of an MIT professor [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] One [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] turn [REDACTED] s [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] to [REDACTED] hunt [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] its [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]
[REDACTED] community [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] too much [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED] urge [REDACTED] communities [REDACTED] to [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] enact strong, meaningful
protections [REDACTED] of life [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED] announce [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] safety [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] enforcement [REDACTED]
[REDACTED] sharing with [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] cities [REDACTED] stop [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED] kill [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED] reassure [REDACTED] us [REDACTED]

Moses Yang

people are concerned
help people

hold them
accountable

evaluate the scene

and effectively

respond

to America

Lost at sea

*waves waves waves waves waves waves
av find y me waves waves waves waves
waves waves waves waves waves waves
emy asoula adrift es waves waves wav
swaves waves waves waves waves wave
waves w my memories v absorbed a ves
aves waves waves waves waves waves w
ves waves w v my w hope w uncharted wa
es waves waves waves waves waves wav
swaves waves swallowed es waves wave
waves waves waves waves waves waves
aves waves waves by v the a night ves w
ves waves wa and w the s waves waves wa
es wa of s my v d reads wave a l ones. av
swaves waves waves waves waves wave*

Moses Yang

Hold my hand

hold my hand
closer to your body after
you
 push
 me
out
 of
 you
into
 the
 world.

hold my hand
as I burst the bubbles
covering the lining of my lips
with my bibbling babbles
refusing to surrender control
to the airplane diving low
with target locked and ready to fire
but your comforting coos weaken my grip
as you grip my hand gently and
guide the plane to its landing strip

hold my hand
higher than I can reach
as I plant my feet firm
 shakely
stumbling forward about to land face first
only for you to swoop in like an airplane
and root me in place
giving me the courage to run forward
and around
and towards you
to hug you

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hold my hand
as you scold me
with tears streaming down both our faces
blotting the aged-gray carpet with blue stains of sorrow
I cried because
I cheated on my exams
and you were disappointed
in me and that hurt more than the ruler
on my hand and the bruises that followed
you cried because
your heart split in half and ha-
lf with every hit

hold my hand
as you teach me to cook with compassion
and sew with tenderness and love with intention
hoping one day your breathing touch
will live on through mine

hold my hand, mami
now covering yours
smaller than a starfish
but larger than love

hold my hand, mami
so we can walk together now
and

in another life.